[EDWARD BURGESS TO GEORGE BURGESS] *Tabreez, January 9, 1844*

I do not think that I ever told you that the Prince has made me chief magistrate of two villages containing about a thousand inhabitants. I did not mention it to my Mother because I wished to see whether it brought me in anything or not, but now notwithstanding my having made nothing by this business, except a three year old colt, seven sheep and a few baskets of raisins, as I think a few anecdotes of my judgements may amuse you I mention it.

These villages belong to the late Dr Cormicks children and as I was frequently unable to get in their rents I asked the Prince to make me chief of them, which he did. I have to collect the taxes from the village and pay them into the treasury. This is all easy enough but what gives me work is this: according to the customs of the country all these villagers look to me for protection, if they are robbed they come to me to catch the thief, if they are in any way oppressed they come to me to plead their cause before the Prince and see that they have justice done them; to such an extent is this carried that last autumn when I was at the village one day as I was walking along the street a man came to me and said "salaam aleikum" "Peace be unto you" making a low bow. "Well," said I, "what now?" "What now?" said he, "why they have plundered the village, harried it and driven everything away." I knew that this was a figurative way of saying that he had been robbed so I asked him what he had lost he said; "I beg to represent that some months ago I had a most beautiful kettle and it was stolen; as you are the chief of this village it is your duty to listen to our complaints, redress our grievances and find my kettle for me." I did my best to find his kettle but unfortunately without success and not many days ago he came to Tabreez and again bothered me about his kettle! It is true he and his brother had other business which was this; they had cultivated a piece of land near the shores of the lake at immense labour and the chief of the village had taken it from them and given it to some of his own relations. (In Persia there are usually two chiefs to each village the one chosen by the villagers the other appointed by the Govt, the Govt one has the supreme command the other is one of themselves). I gave him an order to have his land again and he went away rejoicing and thinking less about his kettle. There are several men of great respectability and considerable property for Persia, in one of these villages. I was breakfasting with one of them, when I was at the village and he said "would that you had been chief of this village two years ago." I said "Why?"

"Because," said he, "you could have saved me two hundred pounds. I have never myself had any business with you but I hear from others who have, that you spare no pains to see justice done to them. When they come to Tabreez

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